

New Zealand Itinerary

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Contents

- North Island: Cape Reinga, Māori Whispers & a Coldplay Dream
- New Zealand South Island: Where Roads Unfold Like Poetry

North Island: Cape Reinga, Māori Whispers & a Coldplay Dream

Day 1

Auckland → Cape Reinga → Paihia

With a long day ahead and a lot of ground to cover, we began our journey at 8 a.m.—our first official day on the North Island. Compared to the South, this side of New Zealand felt more inhabited, though still charmingly quiet by Indian standards. Auckland, being a bustling city, made the contrast even sharper after 12 days of serene South Island scenery.

We eased into the usual travel rhythm: protein bar breakfast, frequent photo stops, and a lunch break along the way. The North Island greeted us with sweeping green hills and lush valleys—but it was the weather that truly put on a show. We drove through sun, wind, rain, hailstorm, and sunshine again, all in a single stretch. A dramatic prelude to our arrival at **Cape Reinga**.

Standing there, where the **Pacific Ocean meets the Tasman Sea**, felt surreal. The lighthouse—iconic and still—marked more than a geographic point. According to Māori tradition, it's where souls begin their final journey. And in that moment, it truly felt sacred.

Though we skipped the nearby hikes to stay on track, making the journey here was absolutely worth it. Harshit carried the weight of the day behind the wheel—nearly 10 to 11 hours of continuous driving. He never said a word about being exhausted, but I could see it. He always steps up quietly, without complaint.

We reached **Paihia** as the sky turned dark and rain returned. It was Harshit's first time driving in the dark on this trip, and while I'm sure it wasn't easy, he never let it show. By the time we reached the hostel, we were completely drained. Still, we pulled ourselves together, cooked dinner, and joined a lively group in the kitchen. Over shared meals and stories, we listened to others' travel plans and swapped experiences. One fellow traveler stood out—he was collecting favorite singers from everyone's home country, building a playlist to soundtrack his journey across New Zealand. It was such a simple but beautiful idea.

The space buzzed with easy laughter, the strum of a guitar, wisps of weed, and spontaneous conversations. The dining area felt like a crossroad of stories—each traveler carrying a little universe of their own. I remember lying down and falling asleep almost instantly—my last waking thought a quiet mix of pride, gratitude, and awe.

Must-Visit Places in Paihia / Bay of Islands

If you ever find yourself in Paihia, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Waitangi Treaty Grounds** – A deeply meaningful historic site marking New Zealand's founding.
- **Paihia Wharf** – Great for coffee on wheels and catching ferries to nearby islands.
- **Haruru Falls** – A short drive or kayak to this photogenic, horseshoe-shaped waterfall.
- **Russell** – A ferry ride away, this old capital offers seaside charm and café culture.
- **Cape Reinga (via road trip)** – Northernmost tip with awe-inspiring ocean views and Māori significance.
- **Scenic Drive from Auckland to Cape Reinga** – A journey in itself through rolling hills, coastal bends, and shifting skies.

Day 2

Paihia → Auckland – Coldplay Dreams & Rainy Roads

total distance covered = 250 km; total time taken = ~3hr

This was easily one of the most thrilling days of Harshit's life. His list of dreams isn't long, but every time we tick one off, I swear I feel even happier than he does. This was *the* day we'd built the whole trip around—**Coldplay concert day**.

The drive from Paihia to Auckland was meant to take about three hours but rain and a blocked road added more stress than expected. We barely made it on time—just enough for a quick Indian lunch, a moment to freshen up at our apartment (a charming white house with a garden), and then it was off to the stadium.

Let me backtrack a little. The morning began with a visit to the historic **Māori Treaty Grounds**—rich in culture and meaning. We skipped **Lake Paihia** since time was tight, but we did stop for coffee from a heartwarming little “Coffee on Wheels” van, run by an uncle who'd turned his passion for being a barista into a mobile café. His joy was infectious.

After that, we took one stop to **Whangarei Falls** along the way and then straight to Auckland and stopped for lunch at an Indian restaurant. I wasn't feeling the best—some period pain was setting in—so all I really wanted was a comforting meal and a moment to rest. Our apartment turned out to be a pleasant surprise: a spacious white house with a garden, peaceful and inviting. The owner wasn't around, which gave us a little more breathing room to settle in.

We got ready and made our way to the stadium, but a drizzle and closed stadium roads made parking an ordeal. Still, we were determined. Just as we reached the venue, a fresh wave of panic hit: we hadn't downloaded the proper tickets, and the ones we had didn't include the gate number. A security guard looked at our version and casually warned us that they *might be fake*. My heart sank. I remember thinking, *this can't be happening*. The entire trip had been building up to this moment.

After some frantic rechecking (and praying for the internet to cooperate), we finally retrieved the real tickets and were let in. Just like that, the weight lifted.

And then... magic. The stadium, the energy, the lights—a full-body experience. It was raining lightly, but thankfully our seats were under cover, with a far view that still gave us a perfect glimpse of the stage and backstage. We grabbed burgers and settled in.

The concert spanned three unforgettable hours—starting with 90 minutes of powerful openers. **Emmanuel Kelly**, the differently abled pop star, radiated heart and resilience, while **Ayra Starr**, the soulful Nigerian singer, brought an infectious energy that had the crowd moving even through the drizzle. And then came 90 minutes of **Coldplay magic**—pure, soaring, luminous. Every lyric, every light, every beat felt like it was stitched directly into the sky. **The rain stopped just as Chris and the band took the stage**. There was something deeply moving about seeing them live for the first time. They brought up local artists, performing **“We Pray” in both English and Māori**—a moment that still gives me chills.

Time vanished in that stadium. We laughed, sang along, cried a little. And when it ended, we noticed something else: the calm. No pushing, no yelling, no traffic chaos. People just made their way home, still carrying the joy of those last few hours.

We reached the apartment and posted a flood of videos to Instagram. Harshit wore the widest smile—I've rarely seen him that radiant. Watching him enjoy this dream fulfilled... it hit me differently. We fell asleep with our hearts full and faces still lit up.

Must-Visit Places in Auckland

If you ever find yourself in Auckland, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Viaduct Harbour** – Perfect for a sunset stroll, gelato in hand, and a final breath of city charm.
- **Eden Park Stadium** – Where unforgettable concerts like Coldplay come alive in sound and light.
- **Auckland Domain & Wintergardens** – A peaceful escape with glasshouses and botanical beauty.
- **Mount Eden** – Climb or drive up for panoramic views over the city and harbor.
- **Newmarket & Ponsonby** – Trendy hubs for shopping, cafés, and local flair.
- **Auckland War Memorial Museum** – An insightful collection of Māori history and cultural heritage.
- **Waitākere Ranges (for day trippers)** – Rainforests and black-sand beaches just outside the city.

Day 3

Auckland → Tauranga → Rotorua – Kane Vibes & Māori Magic

total distance covered = 300 km; total time taken = ~3.5hr

The next morning brought a lovely surprise—our host turned out to be an Indian woman from Mumbai, now living in New Zealand with her European partner. She'd recently bought the house, and over a heartfelt breakfast conversation, we swapped stories of our experiences—hers spanning 14 years in New Zealand, ours still unfolding one memory at a time.

I wasn't feeling too great, courtesy of my period, but Harshit, ever thoughtful, offered to do one more stretch drive. This time, it was just for me—to **Tauranga—for the sheer joy of indulging my fan-girl spirit for Kane Williamson**. The weather, ever moody, followed us with rain again. I mostly dozed off during the drive while Harshit steered us through winding roads and scattered showers.

Tauranga didn't disappoint—another charming town wrapped in coastal calm. We treated ourselves to a mouth-watering lunch at **Lone Star Café**, a cozy spot that felt like just the recharge we needed. Then we made our way to **Mount Maunganui, an extinct volcano and sacred Māori site**, where the ocean-view trails offered a serene moment of reflection before the next leg of our journey. From there, we continued toward Rotorua, where the cultural heart of New Zealand was ready to welcome us with stories, steam, and song.

Rain continued to walk beside us as we checked into our hostel, where we were greeted—once again—by an Indian receptionist. A comforting familiarity in a foreign land.

After a short rest, we were picked up by a nearby bus for our evening experience: **a Māori cultural evening filled with stories, food, language, and dance**. We had our doubts about the veg options, but to our surprise, there were plenty. The show guided us through their traditional way of life—ancient war tactics, carving styles, song, and, of course, the famous Haka dance. It was immersive and powerful, and we felt genuinely honored to be part of it.

When the bus dropped us back at the hostel, we wound down with some quiet TV and drifted off, carrying both the drizzle and the drumbeats of the day into our dreams.

Must-Visit Places in Tauranga / Mount Maunganui

If you ever find yourself in Tauranga, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Mount Maunganui** – Hike to the summit for panoramic ocean views or unwind at the beach below.
- **Pilot Bay & Marine Parade** – A beautiful coastal stretch for relaxing walks and sea breezes.

- **McLaren Falls Park** – Waterfalls, glowworms at night, and peaceful picnic spots.
- **Kaiate Falls** – A local gem tucked into native bush with a series of cascading pools.
- **Downtown Tauranga** – Boutique cafés, galleries, and quiet city charm.
- **Kane Williamson's hometown spark** – A nice extra touch for cricket fans!

Day 4

Rotorua – Ziplines, Mud Baths & Classic Slips

total distance covered = 70 km; total time taken = ~1hr

Another thrilling day on the North Island—this one packed with ziplines, volcanoes, and muddy laughter. I had booked a **Canopy Tour**, along with visits to a volcanic site and a sulphur mud bath. The canopy adventure began bright and early at 7:45 a.m., so we were up, dressed, and at their office by 7:30. It was drizzling—just enough to add a touch of forest magic without dampening the spirit.

Our group was small—just four of us, guided by two incredibly encouraging souls. As expected, I panicked at the first zipline. But with Harshit and the guides cheering me on, I stepped off that platform—and then there was no turning back. There were **six ziplines in total**, each more exhilarating than the last. Along the way, we learned about conservation efforts, native birds, and the delicate balance of the ecosystem. We spotted the **Silver Fern**, it is more than just a botanical wonder—it's a proud emblem of New Zealand identity. To the Māori, it symbolizes strength and guidance, especially under moonlight. Historically, its silvery-white fronds helped people navigate bush paths at night, and today it unites Kiwis as a national icon, seen on everything from sports jerseys to soldiers' memorials. I ended the tour not just with adrenaline, but a quiet sense of accomplishment for overcoming that initial fear. I owe that moment to Harshit and the guides.

Next stop: **Hell's Gate Geothermal Reserve**, a **volcano tour**, where steaming geothermal features reminded us of the raw energy bubbling beneath New Zealand's serene surface. And then it was time for the **sulphur mud bath**—therapeutic, earthy, and hilarious... especially because *Harshit slipped*, true to tradition. Honestly, I'm convinced a trip isn't officially complete until Harshit has at least one dramatic tumble. We got to carve on wood in the thermal reserve.

After braving the mist and rain all day, comfort food called. We headed to an Indian restaurant, roamed through Rotorua's shops for a while, and finally returned to our cozy stay. A home-cooked dinner, some TV, and a long exhale wrapped up the day just right.

Must-Visit Places in Rotorua

If you ever find yourself in Rotorua, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Rotorua Canopy Tours** – Glide through native forests and learn about birdlife and conservation.
- **Wai-O-Tapu Thermal Wonderland** – Surreal geothermal colors and bubbling pools.
- **Polynesian Spa** – Lakeside hot pools perfect for unwinding tired muscles.
- **Te Puia** – A blend of geysers, Māori carving, cultural performances, and craft.
- **Redwoods Treewalk** – Suspended bridges among ancient trees, especially magical after dark.
- **Hell's Gate Mud Bath & Spa** – Relaxing soak meets comic misadventure (cue: Harshit's slip ■).
- **Māori Cultural Evening** – A powerful blend of haka, history, storytelling, and shared meals.

Day 5

Rotorua → Waitomo → Auckland – Glowworms, Gelato & Goodbyes

total distance covered = 400 km; total time taken = ~5Hr

The final day of our journey arrived with clear skies—as if New Zealand itself had come out to say goodbye. With much ground to cover before our late-night flight (1am), we left Rotorua early and made our way to the **Waitomo Glowworm Caves**. Beneath the earth's surface, we drifted through a galaxy of tiny lights—nature's own constellation woven into stone. The history of the caves and the bioluminescence of the glowworms added a soft enchantment to our last adventure.

We stopped for lunch on the way, letting the day unfold without hurry. Back in Auckland, we wandered along the harbour, savoring one final gelato and wrapping up with a little chocolate shopping—souvenirs that could never quite match the sweetness of the memories.

As always, there were rituals to close the chapter: we cleaned and returned our beloved car, that wheeled companion through every twist, drizzle, and glowing valley. The sun stayed with us until the end, a parting gift.

At the airport, we looked back on 16 days of wonder. It passed in a blink—but what a blink it was. I don't know when we'll return, but I know this: **New Zealand doesn't just make you fall in love with it—it spoils you for anywhere else.**

Must-Visit Places in Waitomo

If you ever find yourself in Waitomo, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Waitomo Glowworm Caves** – Sail beneath a galaxy of bioluminescent magic.
- **Ruakuri Cave** – Spiraling limestone formations and ethereal cave walks.
- **Black Water Rafting** – For the thrill-seekers—tubing through underground rivers and caverns.
- **Marokopa Falls** – One of NZ's most beautiful and accessible waterfalls.
- **Mangapohue Natural Bridge** – Limestone arch formed over centuries, best visited at twilight.

Summary of the North Island Road Trip

The North Island wasn't just a geographical shift—it was a rhythm change. It asked more of us: longer drives, unpredictable skies, and choices made with heart over convenience. From the sacred stillness of Cape Reinga, where oceans kissed under a lighthouse and Māori legends breathed through the breeze, to Harshit driving 11 hours without a single complaint—every moment was stitched with silent strength.

Paihia wasn't just a pitstop. It was late-night laughter in hostel kitchens, strangers swapping Spotify songs from their homelands, and that soft hum of camaraderie that only travelers understand. Then came Coldplay. A day so charged with emotion—from lost tickets and drizzled chaos to stadium lights and three golden hours of sound and soul. Watching Harshit beam as Chris Martin sang was the kind of joy that tugs behind your ribs.

Rotorua gave us its volcanic breath—steam, mud, haka drums, and stories that stretched centuries. You ziplined through misty forests despite your fear, stepped off trembling but landed flying. We slipped (well, he did), we giggled, we got mud on our skin and memories on our hearts. And all through it, rain became less of a hindrance and more of a signature.

The final drive led us underground into Waitomo's starlit caves, followed by one last gelato by Auckland's harbor. We handed back the car that had carried our snacks, our chaos, our silence, and our system of suitcases. The sun showed up for goodbye.

This wasn't a holiday. It was a mosaic: of concert wristbands and café coffees, of Kane Williamson detours and hostel conversations, of moments unplanned and fears overcome. The North Island didn't sweep us off our feet—it walked beside us, through rain and sun, teaching us presence, patience, and the beauty of holding space for the unexpected.

We arrived as travelers. We left a little softer, a little braver, and a lot more full.

New Zealand South Island: Where Roads Unfold Like Poetry

From the moment we stepped off the plane in Christchurch, the South Island welcomed us like a hand-painted canvas—gardens in bloom, homes with soul, and skies that whispered freedom. It felt like nature had slowed down just enough to let us catch our breath.

Our road trip carved its way through moody coastlines and misty peaks. We wandered the quirky steepness of Baldwin Street in Dunedin and soaked in the quiet calm of Te Anau, where the lake mirrored towering snowcapped giants. The Milford Sound cruise was our eighth-wonder moment—coffee in hand, dolphins dancing, waterfalls thundering around us, and not a single care beyond the horizon.

Day 1

Touchdown in Christchurch – A City Straight Out of a Painting

After a long journey, we finally landed in **Christchurch** at 6 PM, greeted by a breathtaking landscape that looked like it had been plucked straight from a painting. As we made our way to the baggage claim, the sheer beauty of the city left us in awe.

With heavy luggage and travel fatigue setting in, we grabbed some **information pamphlets** to get a sense of the city and booked an **Uber** to reach our accommodation—**Sandy Feet Lodge**. However, our first adventure in New Zealand came sooner than expected! On the way, our Uber got into a minor accident, with the other car's mirror breaking. I was too busy admiring the charming homes with their lush gardens to figure out whose fault it was.

Upon arrival, we lugged our familiar travel companions—**one heavy blue suitcase, a lighter black one, and our two trusty backpacks**—up the stairs and into what would be our little sanctuary for the night. With only a **microwave and kettle** available, we made ourselves a simple meal—**tea and pasta**—before repacking our luggage strategically.

We decided to keep our **blue suitcase in the trunk**, packing three days' worth of clothes in the **black suitcase**, snacks and food in **one backpack**, and all handy essentials like **caps, chargers, and toiletries** in the **other backpack**. This system worked well, as the backseat of our car would soon be occupied by another suitcase.

With an early start ahead—our **car pickup scheduled for 8 AM**—we called it a night, excited for the road trip that awaited us.

Day 2

Road Trip to Dunedin – A Journey Through Scenic Wonders

With an early start at **8 AM**, we took an **Uber to Omega Rental** to pick up our car—a **Toyota Aqua Hybrid**. Adjusting to the hybrid system took Harshit a moment, but soon enough, we were on our way to **Dunedin**, embarking on one of the most scenic routes in New Zealand.

The route—stretching from Christchurch to Dunedin and further through Bluff and Invercargill to Te Anau—is easily one of the most scenic stretches in all of New Zealand. Endless coastlines, rolling hills, and sun-drenched skies made every kilometer feel like a postcard coming to life. One mobile was mounted on a small handheld tripod, ready to capture fleeting moments. Our journey was fueled not just by wanderlust, but meticulous planning. Before even boarding our flight from India, we had mapped each day's route on Google Maps—pinning every scenic lookout and hidden gem. That

preparation became our lifeline; as the miles piled on and fatigue crept in, our mapped-out plans kept us steady and on course.

Stops Along the Way

- **Moeraki Boulders** – These massive, spherical stones scattered along the beach were a fascinating sight. The strong **winds** made our visit brief, but we managed to snap some great pictures.
- **Penguin Colony** – Watching penguins from a distance was delightful, though Harshit joked they looked more like a **bunch of crows**. The unpredictable **New Zealand weather** lived up to its reputation—sunshine, wind, rain, and back to sunshine, all within a few hours!
- **Lunch by the Shore** – We'd started the day with just a couple of protein bars for breakfast—quick and easy, but not exactly filling. By 1 p.m., we scouted the area for a proper meal and stumbled upon a cozy café right by the shoreline, nestled next to the penguin colony. With waves crashing nearby and curious penguins waddling in the distance, we devoured a piping hot pizza that tasted like pure salvation.

Most days on this trip followed a familiar rhythm. We'd wake up, freshen up, and munch on protein bars or snacks to kick things off. Lunch usually meant grabbing a pizza somewhere affordable—simple, tasty, and easy on the wallet. Come evening, we'd wind down by cooking rice or a ready-to-eat MTR meal wherever we were staying. It wasn't glamorous, but it worked—and gave our days a comforting kind of flow.

Exploring Dunedin

Upon reaching **Dunedin**, the drizzle welcomed us, but that didn't stop us from exploring:

- **Baldwin Street** – The **steepest street in the world!** Though I couldn't help but think we might have roads just as steep back in India, walking it in boots was no joke. Just as I was catching my breath, a guy casually pedaled up on a bicycle—goals!
- **Lilliput Library** – On the same street, I saw a charming little box on a tree with a quote: *"Pick any book and keep any book."* I picked a **mindfulness book**, promising myself I'd return someday to leave another book behind.
- **Larnach Castle** – New Zealand's **only castle**, perched on a hill with stunning views of the city. Unfortunately, it was closed when we arrived, but we soaked in the misty drive.

Before heading to our apartment, I looked for supermarkets to substitute our usual Dmart. We discovered **Pak'nSave, The Warehouse, Four Square, and Woolworths**. Another quiet ritual took root during our travels—visiting at least one local supermarket in every city we stayed in. It all began in Dunedin, sparked by a wave of tiredness and the simple craving for pav bhaji. We figured we'd just grab some bread, but Pak'nSave's tempting aisles had other plans. Bigger than Dmart, and—according to Harshit—the only place left to match now was Walmart. We walked out with Coke, snacks, and enough groceries to last the next leg of the trip. One cool thing about shopping in New Zealand? Their products come with health ratings, making it easier to pick between brands.

Our apartment had a unique layout—kitchen, hall, and bathroom downstairs, while rooms were upstairs. The bathtub was a nice touch, though the room heater wasn't great, but exhaustion made it irrelevant. We cooked **pav bhaji**, turned on the hot AC, and relaxed on the sofa, wrapping up another incredible day.

What I loved most about our holiday rhythm was how naturally it steered us away from screens. Early mornings, early nights, and barely any scrolling. With sunsets painting the sky around 8 p.m., we'd

usually be home by 9 or 9:30 and fast asleep not long after. That kind of peace? Unmatched.

Day 3

A Journey Through Bluff & Invercargill to Te Anau

With a long day ahead, we started early—though Harshit managed to sneak in some **bathtub time** before we hit the road at 8:30 AM. Armed with protein snacks, we embarked on another scenic drive, heading towards **Te Anau**, a breathtaking village nestled near Fiordland National Park.

Stops Along the Way

- **Bluff** – The **southernmost point** of New Zealand's South Island, where the first tribes settled. The **Tasman Sea** was roaring, and despite the heavy **rain**, we visited the lighthouse and Bluff Point. There's something deeply calming about the chaos of the ocean—it silences the noise within.
- **Fueling Up** – Petrol prices varied across stations, so we tracked rates via an app. As Indians, we weren't used to self-service fueling, so it took some guidance!
- **Scenic Stops & Lookouts** – We paused at various lookout points, capturing countless photos and videos. The best part? No need for detailed maps—NZ's road signs guide you to all the scenic spots.

After lunch, we continued our journey to Te Anau, cruising along New Zealand's scenic Highway 95. What we didn't realize then was that this stretch of road would quietly rewrite our definition of beauty—our neural networks forever recalibrated by the sheer magic of the views.

When we reached Te Anau, it felt like stepping into a dream. On one side of the road stood our hostel; on the other, an endless lake framed by towering, cloud-kissed mountains. A seaplane rested near the shore like it, too, was pausing to take in the view. We checked in and were delighted to find a glass wall in our room—those mountains now felt like quiet guests, keeping us company.

After nearly eight hours on the road, we were understandably worn out. But a warm meal with a view helped recharge us. Te Anau, more a charming village than a bustling town, invited us to slow down. After dinner, we wandered through its scenic paths, soaking in the peace. We capped off the evening with ice cream in hand and contentment in our hearts, before heading back to prepare for one of the most anticipated parts of the trip tomorrow: **Milford Sound — a 2-hour drive from Te Anau**. We repacked our blue bag for the next three days, hoping to catch a glimpse of the Southern Lights. Unfortunately, the sky wasn't clear that night, so we called it a day, ready for an early 6 AM start.

Day 4

Milford Sound & Arrival in Queenstown

The day we'd been waiting for—Milford Sound. Our cruise was set for 9:45 a.m., so we planned to leave by 6:30 to give ourselves time to find free parking and walk to the terminal. The alarm rang at 5 a.m. and outside, it was a biting -1°C. Thank goodness for our Decathlon haul—those thermal pants and jackets turned out to be lifesavers.

While I got ready and layered up, Harshit braved a quick hot shower. We both stepped out into the freezing morning, camera in hand, and caught the sunlight just beginning to stretch across the sky. The car windshield was dusted with snow, so we pulled up a video tutorial and carefully cleared it off before heading out around 6:45.

Despite the cold, the moment we slid into the car, a calm warmth settled over us. The outside world was glowing—snow melting into sunlight, mountains and lakes unfurling in slow-motion beauty.

Milford Sound is often called the *eighth wonder of the world*, and honestly, the road leading there felt no less enchanted. Every curve brought a new backdrop—snow-capped peaks, shimmering water, lush green valleys.

We managed to find a free parking spot, and thankfully, the walk to the cruise terminal wasn't far. We resisted every urge to pull over for photos—we'd made a pact to save those for the drive back. For now, all focus was on making it to the cruise on time.

And wow, it delivered. Milford Sound was every bit the marvel it's hyped up to be. **Towering cliffs, graceful waterfalls, penguins skimming past, dolphins** dancing in the water. The fiords were otherworldly, more majestic in person than any photo or description could ever do justice. Standing on the deck with a hot coffee in hand, wrapped in layers, surrounded by that raw, silent beauty—it was one of those rare moments that makes you feel small in the best way possible.

After the cruise, we wandered around, soaking in every corner of Milford Sound and clicking what must have been a thousand pictures. No matter how many we took, though, they all felt like pale imitations of the real thing. That landscape lingers with you, even after you step off the boat. Lunch was at the only restaurant around, and for vegetarians, there was just one option on the menu. But honestly, with a view like that, nature had already stolen the show.

We began our drive back toward Te Anau with a little less energy than we had in the morning, but with cameras still clicking. Every turn seemed to offer another chance to remember this road forever. Somewhere between frames, we remembered we'd left our cold drink and food back at the Te Anau hostel. It was on the way anyway, so we made a quick stop to check—but no luck finding them. No big deal; we had new memories to gather.

By evening, we rolled into Queenstown—a town that buzzes with energy yet feels wrapped in magic. Finding free parking was a bit of a puzzle, but we cracked it with some extra walking. That night, we cooked dinner at the hostel and then wandered into town to explore. We were staying close to **Patagonia Ice Cream and the famous Fergburger**, which felt like living next to temptation itself.

At Patagonia, I asked the receptionist for a flavor recommendation. The moment I mentioned Venice, her eyes lit up—she'd been there too and agreed: best gelatos. And just like that, food became our common language. We picked two Patagonia scoops, and oh my gosh—what a treat. Even months later, I can still taste them. So many choices, so many flavors calling your name. For the first time ever, the cold got to me before the ice cream did. I tucked the rest into the fridge to savor later.

By the time we strolled back to the hostel, light drizzle had begun to fall—gentle, soothing. After such a full day, we wrapped ourselves in that quiet calm and called it a night.

Day 5

Glenorchy & Exploring Queenstown

We began the day with plans to visit Glenorchy and later soak in the charms of Queenstown. But, as always, the weather had a say in things. After a cozy breakfast at the hostel, we set off. Queenstown's beauty made it impossible to drive straight through—every twist in the road offered another photo-worthy view, and we happily gave in to each one.

By the time we reached Glenorchy, the rain had caught up with us. We ducked into a café for a comforting coffee-and-cupcake break, watching the drizzle fall over the sleepy village. We visited the iconic **Glenorchy Hut**, once a harbor spot and now a postcard-perfect red landmark that added a splash of charm to the grey skies. Honestly, every corner of New Zealand feels like a contender for “favorite place”—picking one is a losing game in the best way.

We drove back to Queenstown and spent the rest of the day meandering through its streets. We treated ourselves to the iconic **Ferg Burger and Ferg Gelato** (a combo I now fully endorse), picked up souvenirs for family, and learned a little more about what makes NZ tick—wool, honey, jade jewelry, and the kinds of local cookies that vanish far too quickly.

With the weather slowing things down, it turned into a gentle day. We wrapped it up by repacking our bags for the next leg of the trip, hearts full and ready for what tomorrow might bring.

Day 6 & 7

Mount Cook & Tasman Glacier – A Journey into the Stars

Today was going to be a long one, so we started early—chasing the quiet majesty of New Zealand's highest peak. Mount Cook Village, nestled in one of the country's dark sky reserves, holds a charm that awakens the soul. On our way, **Lake Pukaki** stunned us with its surreal clarity—honestly, one of the cleanest lakes I've ever seen. We stopped briefly, capturing its mirror-like stillness before continuing our journey. Along the way, we stopped at **Lindis Pass** which sweeps through golden high country, offering dreamy alpine views that shift with the light. Not far away, the **Clay Cliffs of Omarama** rise in jagged grandeur—towering, cathedral-like formations sculpted by nature's hand. Both are must-sees on a South Island road trip. Then we stopped at **Lake Pukaki**, known for its **crystal-clear waters**, capturing its surreal beauty in photos.

Upon reaching **Mount Cook Village** around **lunchtime**, we wasted no time heading straight for a meal, having only had **protein bars for breakfast**. After refueling, we visited the **Sir Edmund Hillary Alpine Centre**, located inside the **Hermitage Hotel**—a place we couldn't stay but had no regrets about missing. Our accommodation at **Haka House Hostel** turned out to be a fantastic choice, offering a **great location and cozy atmosphere**.

With coffee and dessert still warming our hands, we popped into the village museum where we learned about the Tasman Lake hike. It was short enough to finish before sunset, so we swapped into hiking shoes in the car and set off. And then came the moment—the **Tasman Glacier** stretched before us, quiet and magnificent.

The Tasman Glacier – A Moment of Awe

All the talk about glaciers evaporating, about their role in keeping our planet balanced—it hits different when you're standing there in person. The hike was a bit of a climb, but the view was worth every step. A kind of calm washed over me, the kind you don't forget. This was one of those moments that **stay with you forever**, reminding you why travel is **worth every effort**. The hustle of **city life in India** felt justified if it led to experiences like this.

We video-called our parents and siblings from the glacier. My travel puzzle still has one piece missing: my family. I'm not sure if the five of us will ever roam the world together, but until then, I make it a point to call from the most iconic places I reach—so they can be part of the journey too.

Back at Haka House, we cooked dinner and later lay out on the hostel deck, star-gazing under a velvet sky. We spotted planets, constellations, and even the Starlink satellite - tiny sparks in a vast galaxy. We checked the Alpine Centre again for any telescope tours, even though I'd already booked one for Lake Tekapo the next day. Nothing was available, and night driving felt risky, so we stayed in. Harshit was still tempted to see more stars, but with tomorrow's big trek ahead, I nudged us both toward sleep. We finally drifted off around 1 a.m., wrapped in mountain air and starlight.

Day 8

Hooker Valley Trek & Arrival in Lake Tekapo

The **main trek day** had arrived! Though we started a bit late, the **weather was perfect**—a mix of **sunshine and wind**, making the hike enjoyable. After **breakfast and checkout**, we set off for the **Hooker Valley Trek** at **10:30 AM**.

The Mueller Hut Trek, Sealy Tarns Trek, and other trails branched out from the same spot, but we chose Hooker Valley—a **3-hour trek** that took us **4.5 hours** because we couldn't resist **capturing every breathtaking moment**. The **vastness of the mountains** was overwhelming, pulling us deep into nature's embrace.

Returning **happy, tired, and proud** of completing our **first trek**, we still had a **two-hour drive** ahead to **Lake Tekapo**. Harshit, somehow, managed to power through, and upon reaching **Lake Tekapo Resort**, we **slept off immediately**, exhausted but fulfilled.

A Rainy Evening & Observatory Tour Cancellation

After waking up in the **evening**, we planned to eat out, but the rain made it tricky. Lake Tekapo is a small village, so we grabbed burgers from a food truck and enjoyed a cozy night indoors, flipping through magazines and watching a movie.

At **11 PM**, we got ready for our observatory tour, but doubts lingered—the sky wasn't clear. Unfortunately, the tour was **canceled**, leaving us disheartened. With no choice but to accept nature's unpredictability, we called it a night, hoping for better weather ahead.

Day 9

A Rainy Journey to Fox Glacier

The day started at **9:30 AM**, with plans to explore **Lake Tekapo's scenic spots** before heading to **Fox Glacier**. After visiting the **Church of the Good Shepherd**, the rain set in and didn't stop until nightfall. We spotted famous **Lupins** in the gardens of the Church.

Day 10

Waiting Out the Rain & Journey to Greymouth

The **rain didn't stop**, and unfortunately, we **couldn't see Fox Glacier**. To make matters worse, the **road to Greymouth was closed** due to **fallen trees and flooding**.

The rain just wouldn't let up, and with low visibility, we couldn't see a thing. As if that wasn't enough, the road to Greymouth was closed due to a fallen tree—completely blocking our way forward. With no option but to wait it out, we reconsidered our plans. We thought about canceling our stay in Greymouth and spending the night at Fox Glacier instead. But one thing was non-negotiable: we had to be in Christchurch by the 11th, no matter what, to catch our flight to Auckland.

We chatted with fellow travelers who were also rerouting their plans—some were aiming for Wanaka, but even that road had been closed off. With nowhere to go, we settled into a local café for lunch and waited, hoping for better news. The rain kept pouring, and time moved slower than usual. Our hostel host kindly let us hang out in the common hall, which gave us a dry place to pause and regroup.

When word finally came that the roads were open, we packed our bags and made a move. But barely half a kilometer in, the police stopped us—it still wasn't safe to continue. So, we turned back, parked our car, and turned the wait into a quiet moment—we watched a movie from the comfort of our seats,

the rain tapping softly on the windshield.

Luckily, by around 3 p.m., the skies began to clear, and the road to Greymouth reopened—our journey could finally continue. We made our way to Greymouth by evening, weary but grateful to have moved forward. After a comforting home-cooked dinner, we took a short walk to stretch our legs. A light drizzle greeted us once again, softly blurring the edges of the day, but somehow it felt different—less of an obstacle, more of a gentle sign-off to an unpredictable chapter.

Sometimes, travel reminds us that plans may change, but **every journey has its own story to tell. As the rain drizzled on, the road still stretched ahead, and the adventure continued.**

Day 11

Greymouth to Christchurch via Pancake Rocks & Arthur's Pass

Finally, the sun returned—piercing through after two straight days of rain and setting the perfect tone for our last full day on the South Island. We began with a visit to the remarkable **Pancake Rocks in Punakaiki**. Science may still be puzzled by their formation, but nature, as always, finds a way to leave us speechless. The layered cliffs, shaped by wind and sea, looked like they belonged to another world.

After lunch, we continued toward **Christchurch via Arthur's Pass**—another route famed for its alpine beauty and wild charm. We paused often for photos, trying to capture just a fraction of the South Island's magic. It felt fitting, somehow, to be leaving this leg of the journey through winding roads framed by towering peaks and sprawling valleys.

Technically, it was our final day here, and the South Island left a lasting impression. It's sparsely populated, yet that very stillness adds to its untouched appeal. We humans tend to shape nature to suit our comfort, often at the cost of its essence. But here, in these wild landscapes, the beauty remains unedited—and breathtaking.

Back in Christchurch, we made one last stop at Pak'nSave—a full-circle moment from the ritual we'd unknowingly started in Dunedin. Just as we were planning to stretch the day with a visit to Hagley Park, the rain returned, nudging us gently indoors. So we made our way to the apartment and began the quiet task of packing. Everything from the car's back seat found its way into our luggage—each item a small marker of stories we've lived along the way.

Day 12

Farewell South Island, Hello Auckland – A Day of Transitions

It was time to **say goodbye to the South Island**, and with it, the chapter of serene landscapes, winding roads, and unforgettable memories. Before returning our trusty rental car, we realized it needed a good clean. Harshit found a self-service automatic car wash—something pretty new for us as Indians. Cleaning the car turned into an unexpected little adventure.

I took charge of the inside, using a high-pressure hose and choosing the “fragrance finish.” Then we settled into our seats while the car rolled along an automated belt, getting lathered and rinsed until it sparkled. At the rental return, someone casually complimented my “lovely perfume” and even joked about how lucky Harshit was. That's when it hit me that I was smelling nice — because of the *car fragrance!* and I'm definitely not used to receiving compliments like that since I don't really wear perfumes.

The **car return was smooth**, and we were dropped off at the airport for our flight to Auckland. Once we landed, we needed to pick up a new rental car. Eventually, our ride arrived, we picked up the car, and made our way to the hostel—where we were pleasantly surprised with a **room upgrade** for a

minimal cost. A small win after a long transition day.

Then came the big decision: **Should we drive to Cape Reinga tomorrow?** It would mean an **800 km stretch** in a single day for Harshit. But the allure of **Cape Reinga**, where the Tasman Sea meets the Pacific Ocean and where, according to Māori tradition, souls begin their final journey, was too powerful to resist. After much deliberation, we repacked our black bag for the next three days and committed to the adventure.

With the South Island behind us and the northernmost tip of New Zealand ahead, we drifted off to sleep—ready to chase the horizon once more. ■■■

Must-Visit Places in South Island

If you ever find yourself road-tripping through the South Island, here is our ultimate checklist:

- **Milford Sound:** Cruise between sheer cliffs, thundering waterfalls, and wild dolphins.
- **Aoraki / Mount Cook:** Take the Hooker Valley track or hike to the Tasman Glacier.
- **Lake Tekapo:** Stroll among Lupins by the Church of the Good Shepherd and stargaze in the dark sky reserve.
- **Queenstown:** Devour a Fergburger, grab Patagonia Gelato, and gaze over Lake Wakatipu.
- **Pancake Rocks:** Marvel at the geological layered limestone stacks in Punakaiki.
- **Baldwin Street (Dunedin):** Climb the world's steepest street and grab a book at the Lilliput Library.
- **Arthur's Pass:** Drive the spectacular alpine highway between the East and West coasts.
- **Stirling Point (Bluff):** Stand at the windy, dramatic southernmost point of the South Island.

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